UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES **UCLA**

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SANTA BARBARA • SANTA CRUZ

DEPARTMENT OF ATMOSPHERIC AND OCEANIC SCIENCES
7127 MATH SCIENCES BUILDING
405 HILGARD AVENUE
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1565

01/22/2026

Dear Distinguished Teaching Awards Committee,

It is my pleasure to write this cover letter in support of Dominique Stumbaugh's nomination for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant award. As chair of the Atmospheric and Oceanic Sciences Department and Dominique's academic advisor, I have had the opportunity to witness her exceptional dedication to teaching.

Dominique's commitment to improving her pedagogical knowledge is unparalleled. During her time as a PhD student, she has taught three times within the AOS department, two times with the Clusters Program, and four times as the TA Consultant for the Writing Programs unit. She worked at the Graduate Writing Center, consulting with graduate students across UCLA for three years. She has also pursued two different certificates dedicated to pedagogy: the Writing Programs' Graduate Certificate in Writing Pedagogy (GCWP) and the certificate with the Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning (CIRTL). Through the GCWP, Dominique has created grammar tutorials and mini-lessons targeted at various writing issues that arise in her writing seminars. Through CIRTL@UCLA, she earned the Practitioner Certificate for developing and implementing a teaching-as-research project in one of her classes and has plans to earn the Scholar Certificate.

Dominique continues to use her pedagogical expertise to enrich student learning. From holding extra review sessions, giving personalized feedback, and conferencing with each student individually, it is clear that Dominique cares a lot about her students. In 2023, Dominique was awarded the prestigious AOS Morris Neiburger Award, which "… *recognizes outstanding contributions to teaching by graduate students in the Department of Atmospheric and Oceanic Sciences*".

Dominique more than meets the award criteria and I strongly endorse her for the award. Please reach out if you would like more information at jbortnik@atmos.ucla.edu.

Sincerely,



Jacob Bortnik, PhD.
Professor and Department Chair
Michio and Yoko Yanai Endowed Department Chair in Atmospheric and Oceanic Sciences
Department of Atmospheric and Oceanic Sciences
Faculty Director of the UCLA SPACE Institute
University of California at Los Angeles (UCLA)
AGU Fellow and Winner of the 2021 Joanne Simpson Medal for Mid-Career scientists

Self-Statement

During my time as a graduate student at UCLA, I've embraced my inner teacher and taught in different roles and departments for 9 quarters. Once I started teaching, I could not stop. In order to fulfill my long term goal of being a professor and the best educator I can be, I have maximized my time while pursuing my PhD in space physics.

I started teaching as a Teaching Assistant in my home department, Atmospheric and Oceanic Sciences (AOS). I was a TA for AOS 1 Climate Change: From Puzzles to Policy; AOS 101 Fundamentals of Atmospheric Dynamics and Thermodynamics; and AOS 111 Introduction to Machine Learning for the physical sciences. Through TAing these three courses, I discovered that I value collaborative learning. My passion for teaching was honored by my department when I received the Morris Neiburger Award in 2023 for outstanding contributions to teaching in the department. I was evaluated on the quantity and quality of my teaching, and my department specifically recognized how I had incorporated evidence-based teaching methods for AOS 111, an introductory machine learning course. Because of my input, the in-class coding assignments are now graded as low stakes assignments to facilitate experimentation with the code and keep excitement about the topic.

At the end of my second year, I knew I wanted to seek out teaching opportunities in writing. I had just finished a few rounds of writing my own grants and fellowships and had come to understand the importance of writing. I started with UCLA's Graduate Writing Center in the Fall of 2022. The three years I worked at the GWC were very formative for me as I honed my writing, teaching, and communicating skills across all disciplines.

In 2023, I started the Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning's (CIRTL)'s Certificate Program. The first class I took, 'Intro to Evidence-Based Undergraduate Teaching', provided me with the language to express how I was already incorporating evidence-based practices that were conducive to a strong learning environment, like remembering students' names and giving personal feedback. Through the class, I learned new pedagogy including universal design for learning, flipping classrooms, and various activities for active learning that have strengthened my teaching. As of today, I have taken the introduction to evidence-based teaching (GRAD PD 496A) and planning a TAR project (GRAD PD 496B and 496C) courses and have implemented my TAR project, earning me the practitioner level of the certificate. My TAR project titled, "Technology as an Amplifier: Developing and Fostering Students' Agency" explores how integrating multimodal material impacts students' learning and metacognition in a writing course. I plan to present my TAR project's findings and earn the scholar level of the certificate this year.

Another certificate I have pursued is the Writing Program's Graduate Certificate in Writing Pedagogy (GCWP). I was drawn to the GCWP because of their "writing in the Disciplines" emphasis. I want to be able to weave in writing in all of my future classes,

especially for STEM classes as I have done so within the Clusters program. As part of the GCWP, I took the 495 series that accompanies the Clusters program and prepared a writing seminar on artificial intelligence. My seminar's topic explored how artificial intelligence is transforming our society and shaping a future that increasingly relies on it, and considered balancing technological innovation with environmental responsibility. I designed the course to explore best practices in science and technical writing and the process of science journalism. For the GCWP, additional courses I've taken include Language Pedagogy: Form, Meaning, and Function (EngComp 403) and Career Exploration and Preparation Workshop (EngComp 499).

As of today, I serve as the Teaching Assistant Consultant (TAC) for the Clusters. In my two years as the TAC, I get to serve as a resource for fellow graduate students in their teaching journeys, sharing my knowledge and experience teaching inside and outside of the Clusters program.

From AOS to Writing Programs, the teaching community at UCLA is phenomenal and I'm so grateful to the opportunities I've had to learn and lead.

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

My ultimate goal in life is to learn as much as I can, push science as far as it can go, and ready the next generation of critical thinkers to do the same. I aim to create learning environments that are collaborative, creative, and engaging. In my classrooms, I want students to feel comfortable experimenting with new genres of writing or science concepts and embracing a growth mindset.

I find that in order to facilitate learning, I have to understand what prior knowledge students are bringing into the classroom. Prior knowledge consists of the ideas and life experiences that govern students' ability to understand new information and concepts. Sometimes prior knowledge can contain misconceptions. For the climate change course, most students understood global warming to mean just that: warming of the climate. This limited definition hindered their ability to see that some places in the world will see an increase in 'wet' weather and others an increase in 'dry' weather. I worked to link extreme weather to an extreme increase in global temperatures, so that students could connect the material. In my writing seminars, most students have not connected their vetting process of academic sources with that of online material, especially of social media posts. Their narrow understanding of fact checking and its applications is the focus of one of the writing workshops I lead for my seminars (see teaching artifact #3). Students are able to freely reflect on their personal experiences and develop skills to evaluate their sources, both academic and non-academic. Working with, rather than against or indifferently towards, prior student knowledge (and correcting misconceptions) allows me to meet students where they are and encourage them to take on the complexities of thinking that will elevate their writing.

However, meeting students where they are does not mean I wish for them to stay where they are. Just like my students, I struggled with a fixed mindset and wished that my instructors would have helped me through it. As a TA, I focus on expanding my students' system of beliefs to value persistence as a way to develop their scholarship. To encourage students to try without risk of failure, I set up low-stakes assignments that place the emphasis on process rather than product. In the machine learning course, I collaborated with the instructor, Dr. Alex Lozinski, to change the in-class coding assignments to be low pressure and worth less points to facilitate experimentation with the code and maintain excitement about the various weekly topics. We then communicated this change to the class to include them in this process and students responded by taking more time to grapple with the material. Their willingness to sit in the short-term discomfort of debugging their code indicated that the choice to ease the pressure of the grade opened the students' thinking and positively impacted their coding projects. From the end-of-the-term evaluations, one student identified my ability to answer their questions with hints rather than the answers as a strength, pointing to the value of the students' experimentation (see teaching artifact #1, AOS C111).

I also incorporate as much collaborative learning as I can to support students' open but critical thinking skills as they learn from each other. Activities like quick think-pair-shares or more involved quarter-long group work offer students the chance to work on a shared goal and appreciate different perspectives and approaches. In my writing seminar, many learning outcomes touch on the collaborative nature of the class (see teaching artifact #2) because expanding our views is collaborative as much as it is individual. Peer-to-peer and instructor-to-peer feedback is baked into my writing seminars to support writing as a process. Every milestone draft the students turn in and every conference I have with my students lead to better writing because the students are able to claim agency for their work and reflect on past, present, and future steps (see teaching artifact #4). This process also means students are responsible for providing thoughtful feedback to peers and responsive edits in their next drafts. Students gain an awareness of and enter into a dialogue about their own and peers' approaches. It is fulfilling to witness the shift in motivation in my students when they realize they can tackle the new genre of writing or the final machine learning project one step at a time.

As a way to account for different learning styles and develop my students' individuality, I've embraced multimodal content in my writing seminars. I assign podcasts, films, and feature articles along with more traditional readings so that students are granted creative freedom to explore topics more deeply. I have also created short grammar teaching tutorials to inject timely writing interventions throughout the quarter (see teaching artifact #5). Just as I am innovative with my instruction, I encourage students to be creative in their final projects by applying and adapting genre writing conventions to develop a script for a podcast or a more traditional research paper. From surveys I administered, students shared that the media sparked their interest and curiosity and that the visualizations helped them understand concepts differently. I believe writing is an essential skill that requires critical thinking to support an argument and creative thinking to create new, original material. Writing is in every field and I meld science and writing together in my classrooms to ensure my students are independent thinkers, writers, and communicators.

In alignment with my teaching philosophy, I strive to continually improve my teaching skills to provide the best possible learning experience for my students. I iterate every quarter on my lesson plans to refine my sections. I reflect on my teaching through writing, noting ideas for future activities and assignments. Finally, I seek out learning communities (i.e. CIRTL, Writing Programs) as a way to collaborate and bond with other instructors. Through my teaching, I hope my students not only learn through course material, but also gain curiosity and passion so that they can be positive contributors at UCLA and beyond.

Artifact #1 Excerpt of written comments from Student Surveys

Comments on my role as the Teaching Assistant Consultant for Clusters:
Prompt: Please identify what you perceive to be the strengths and weaknesses of this teaching assistant and course.

EngComp 495M (24F and 25F)

- Nique is a very caring, supportive, and accountable person. Having her as a TA greatly enriches the discussions, because she always has many great points to add. Most importantly, she is very responsible, attentive to students' needs, and willing to support.
- Nique is a helpful and engaging TA. Her experience teaching in the Clusters was helpful for addressing practical issues, and her suggestions for classroom activities and practices encourage student–centered and effective teaching.
- She provided helpful and concise feedback on our presentations asking questions that we didn't think about. The course material inspired self-reflection on my own working and teaching process and helped me engage with my students in an effective way.
- I found it helpful that she gave examples of experiences where different techniques have and have not worked and how to ensure techniques are successful as this was practical advice that we can implement ourselves.

EngComp 495N (**25W)**

- Nique was a great TA! I appreciated all that she shared from her own experiences teaching, and her feedback on our work was very helpful as well. I feel very grateful to have gotten to learn from her and well prepared for teaching my class next quarter.
- She knows a lot about writing pedagogy, and she was really qualified as a TA.
- Loved all the personal experiences and examples shared in class. Very powerful and helpful.

Comments on my role as the Teaching Assistant in my home department (AOS):
Prompt: Please identify what you perceive to be the strengths and weaknesses of this teaching assistant and course.

AOS 1 (22S)

- When the TA directly engaged with us and asked us questions, like multiple choice questions, it helped me understand where I need more help in the class.
- Made the room easier to sit in and created a very relaxed environment. Also extremely helpful with any question and seemed genuinely dedicated to educating us.

AOS 101 (22F)

- She was really good at checking in with every student and addressing difficult parts of the homework with the entire section.
- She also makes sure to answer any questions on homework and facilitates a learning environment where students get to help each other and learn from each other.

AOS C111 (23F)

- Pushing students to figure out the answers on their own (with hints) rather than a flat-out answer.
- I feel like she was very understanding of the various skill levels in the class. She never made it feel like a question was too dumb.

Comments on the seminar I taught as part of the Clusters Program:

Prompt: What did you find most interesting about this seminar? What did you find most valuable?

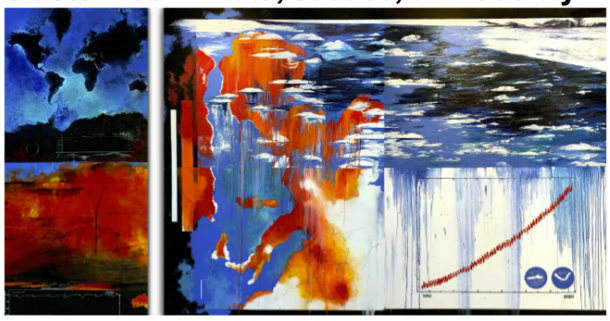
24S and 25S Cluster 10CW

- I found the overall topic about this seminar really interesting. I think it is imperative to educate students regarding the climate crisis that is currently occurring, therefore I found all of the information that was taught very valuable.
- I found this seminar interesting, the content was applicable to the real world and it was interesting to see current events that were happening regarding AI, algorithms, and social media.
- What I found most interesting is how much water AI really uses. What I found most valuable were the writing tips that we reviewed at each seminar.
- I found the open-ended discussions to be most valuable. I almost never speak in front of a class because it brings me a lot of anxiety, but this class somehow got me out of my shell. I regularly spoke during seminar and feel I progressed a lot over the course of the quarter.
- I thought this seminar was very good in seeing the pros and cons of artificial intelligence for the future. I was not that informed on AI before, but now I am. This class even motivated me to maybe even look into a career that relates to working with AI or AI policy.
- I found very valuable researching our own topic related to an Ai application, as I practiced my library skills and also analytical and writing skills.

Artifact #2 Cluster 10CW Syllabus

First two pages of the syllabus:

Artificial Intelligence in the Climate Crisis
Cluster 10CW: Data, Justice, and Society



Diane Burko, "Summer Heat 1 and 2" (2020)

Course Description

Welcome! Artificial intelligence (AI) is transforming our society and shaping a future that increasingly relies on it —but is this a sustainable future? In this class, you will examine the ethical dilemmas of AI in climate action; balancing technological innovation with environmental responsibility. This course explores best practices in science and technical writing and the process of science journalism through close readings and peer review. You will write and revise an original piece on a topic related to AI's usage, along with a compelling Op-Ed, with the option to submit your work for publication.

Course Logistics

Course Dates and Times: Mondays, 9-11:50am
Location: Haines A6
Course Site: https://bruinlearn.ucla.edu/courses/205742

Instructor Information

Instructor: Dominique 'Nique' Stumbaugh (pronounced like 'Nikki")
Department: Atmospheric and Oceanic Sciences Department
Email: dstumbaugh@ucla.edu
Drop-in Chats:
- ➔ Tuesdays 11am-11:50 am in YRL and Thursdays 3pm-3:50 pm on ZOOM LINK
- ➔ If the set hours don't work for you or you'd like to meet 1-on-1, please schedule through my calendly link here

1

Learning Outcomes

The learning outcomes for this course are designed to further develop your writing skills while exploring the topic of artificial intelligence and climate change! By the end of this course, you will be able to:

➔ **Foundational Knowledge**

What key information, ideas, perspectives are important for learners to know?

- Understand and weigh consequences of artificial intelligence's (AI's) use on the environment.
- Identify and explain how society perceives AI through writing.
- Recognize disciplinary and genre writing conventions.

➔ **Integration**

What connections should learners be able to make within and beyond this learning experience?

- Connect your vetting process of academic sources with that of online material (i.e. social media posts).
- Express and reflect on personal experiences with AI.

➔ **Human Dimension**

What should learners learn about themselves and about interacting with others?

- Develop an informed stance about current and future AI applications.
- Participate in productive class discussion, embracing a growth mindset.

➔ **Application**

What kinds of thinking and skills is it important for learners to be able to do?

- Analyze both quantitative and qualitative evidence from a variety of perspectives.
- Apply and adapt disciplinary and genre writing conventions to develop an original claim.
- Draft, revise, and incorporate feedback in your writing.

➔ **Caring**

What changes in learners' feelings, interests, values are important?

- Discover a personal interest in science communication.
- Value the practice and importance of writing as a process.

➔ **Learning How To Learn; Metacognition**

What should learners learn about learning, engaging in inquiry, and becoming self-directed?

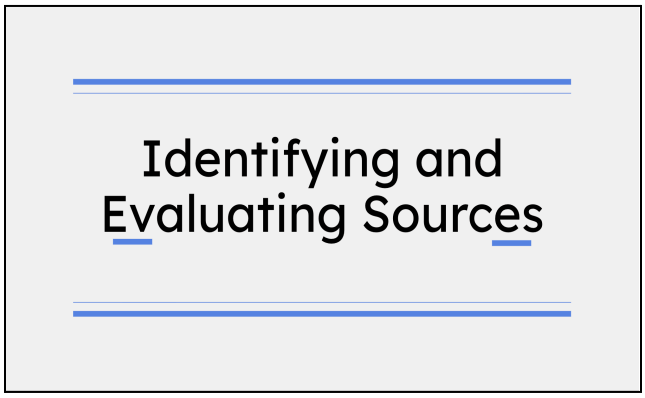
- Become a self-directed learner.
- Reflect on past, present, and future steps via process writing.

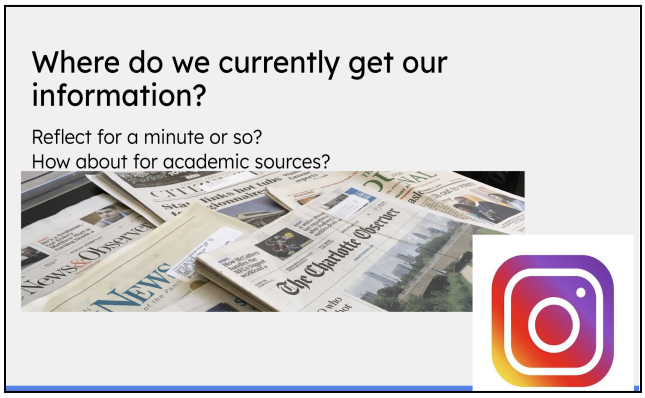
Link to full syllabus: 2025 10CW Syllabus

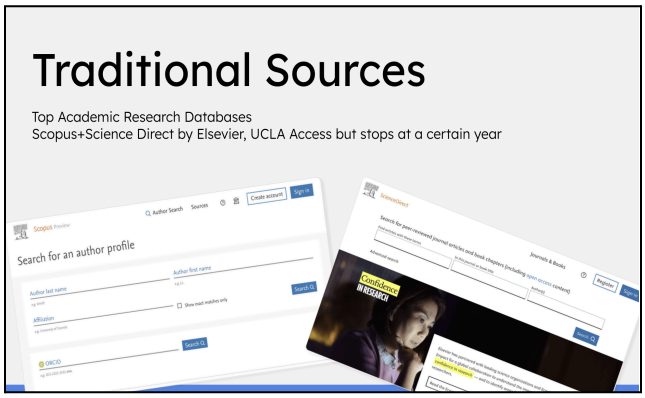
This is an excerpt from the most recent cluster course syllabus I taught in spring of 2025. I am highlighting the learning outcomes of the class to illustrate how I incorporate Fink's taxonomy in my teaching and how I communicate to my students what I want them to learn as a result of the course. I iterated on my past syllabus and employed backwards design for this course and so I started with the learning outcomes, before any lesson planning or assignment charting. By grounding myself in learning outcomes like "value the practice and importance of writing as a process", "participate in productive class discussion, embracing a growth mindset", and "become a self-directed learner", I knew I had to scaffold all main assignments and use low stakes writing throughout the course. Students had many steps of their main assignments due throughout the quarter and kept a weekly "journal" of reactions to the required reading.

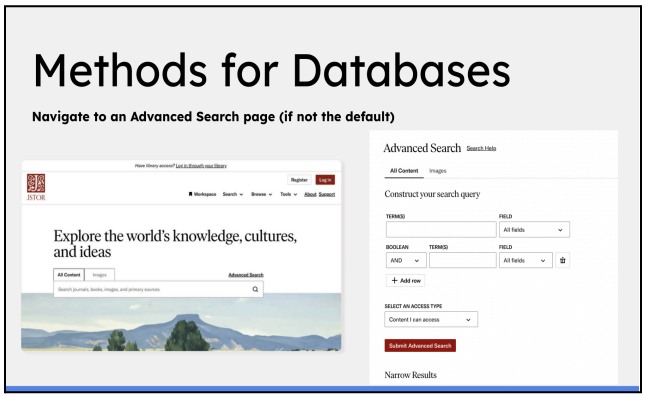
Artifact #3 Identifying and Evaluating Sources Lesson and Activity

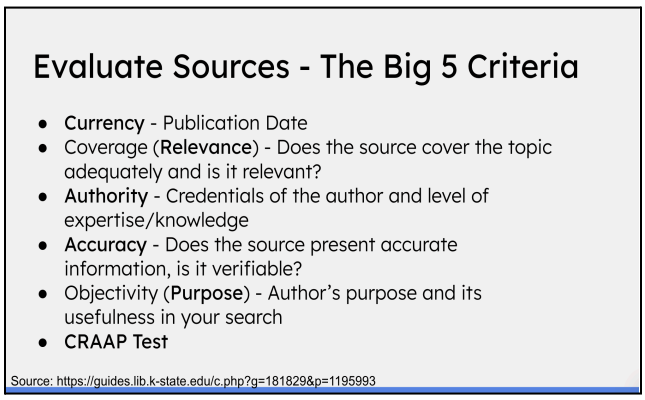
Select Slides from the lesson:

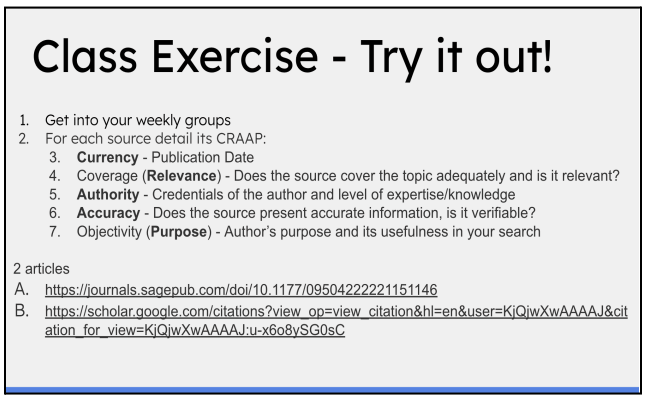












Here is an excerpt from a workshop I've taught for my cluster courses. I go through slides that ask students to identify and reflect on where they source their information for various needs, i.e. social, political, academic, etc. We discuss the appropriateness of traditional academic sources and methods for accessing such databases. I then introduce many tools and frameworks students can use to evaluate sources and ask them to try it out for themselves.

For the activity, I pair up the students and assign each group 1 of 2 papers to evaluate. Both papers are published, but one is to a "scam" publisher and its contents are

US-China Education Review A, April 2020, Vol. 10, No. 4, 158-164
doi: 10.17265/2161-623X/2020.04.002

Unfamiliar Publisher

Experiential Learning in Secondary Education Chemistry Courses: A Significant Life Experiences Framework*

Bradley C. Allf
North Carolina State University, Raleigh, USA
Jesse B. Pinkman, Walter H. White
J. P. Wynne High School, Albuquerque, USA

Coauthors are from a High School AND based off of Breaking Bad

Significant life experiences (SLE), a framework first put forward by Thomas Tanner, is a well-known model for understanding attitudes and perceptions about the environment as ascertained through environmental education (EE) programs. The SLE framework posits that early positive experiences in the environment are strongly correlated with later pro-environmental attitudes and behaviors in adulthood. According to the model, these early experiences facilitate this change through "experiential" learning, as opposed to formal learning experiences in a classroom, or even informal learning. While the SLE framework is often used within the EE literature, it is rarely used to model behavior and learning in the classroom setting. Here, we present a new use of the theory to model experiential learning in a high school chemistry course. We present evidence that a new model of SLE being used experimentally by faculty at a high school in New Mexico has led to significant learning gains among students. Specifically, we find evidence that low-achieving students may particularly benefit from this new model of teaching chemistry in the secondary education setting through the "hands-on" process of manufacturing and distributing methamphetamine (*N*-methyl amphetamine). While this study cohort is small, the authors believe that

Red Flag: High schoolers manufactoring and distributing methamphetamine

of SLE and experiential learning within the broader
n field (theory) and pedagogy (practice).

Keywords: secondary education, significant life experiences, STEM learning, chemistry education

Introduction

Science education (Bates, 1862) has undergone a remarkable evolution in theory and methodology over the past one hundred and fifty years. The 20th century saw the advancement of didacticism and a transformation towards more specialized and field-based learning. Specific subject areas once only taught at the tertiary level advanced into the high school, including disciplines, such as biology, physics, phrenology, and

Unclear writing, nonsense

*Acknowledgements: We thank the J. P. Wynne High School, the Department of the Interior, the Vice-Chancellor of Food Lion's Frozen Foods Division, Vince Gilligan, Katherine LeMasters, and the New Mexico Bar Association for access to the study areas used in this article, as well as graduate student Gale Boetticher for his helpful commentary on this manuscript. The procedures in this study were deemed "exempt" by the University of American Samoa's IRB because of the clearly, extensively limited possibility of any negative repercussions for study subjects (I mean seriously, what could possibly go wrong; protocol #135-32149.0).

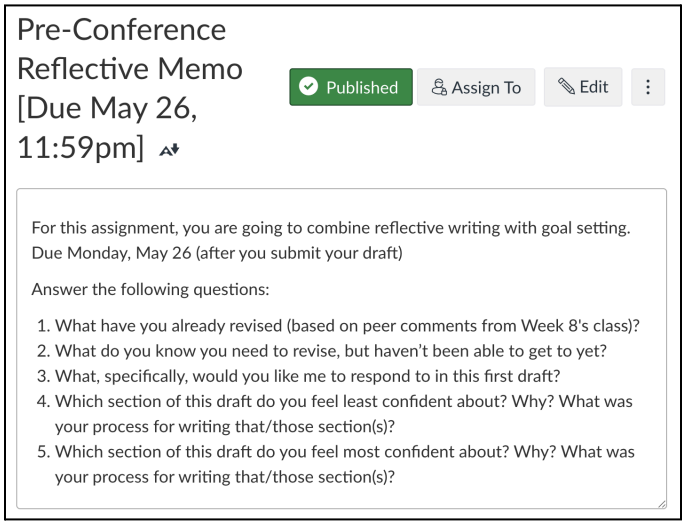
Bradley C. Allf, B.A., lecturer, Department of Forestry and Environmental Resources, North Carolina State University.
Jesse B. Pinkman, H.S. Diploma, assistant professor, Science Instruction Faculty, J. P. Wynne High School.
Walter H. White, Ph.D., professor, Science Instruction Faculty, J. P. Wynne High School.

fabricated. After about 10 minutes of pair work, I ask the class to share what they noted for each paper. Most groups (but not all) catch that the paper was fraudulent and based after the show "Breaking Bad", (see part of the groups' finding in red, to the left).

I have found this lesson to be very fun and show the students the importance of evaluating their sources and not trusting everything that "looks academic."

Artifact #4 Reflective Assignment

Pre-Conference Reflective Prompt



Pre-Conference Reflective Memo [Due May 26, 11:59pm]

Published | Assign To | Edit

For this assignment, you are going to combine reflective writing with goal setting. Due Monday, May 26 (after you submit your draft)

Answer the following questions:

1. What have you already revised (based on peer comments from Week 8's class)?
2. What do you know you need to revise, but haven't been able to get to yet?
3. What, specifically, would you like me to respond to in this first draft?
4. Which section of this draft do you feel least confident about? Why? What was your process for writing that/those section(s)?
5. Which section of this draft do you feel most confident about? Why? What was your process for writing that/those section(s)?

Student Sample Response

1. Since the peer review, I have revised the general flow and structure of my essay, mostly by rewording/rewriting awkward sentences, swapping my counterpoint and body paragraphs so that the last body paragraph supports the refutation of the counterpoint. Additionally, I revisited the evidence in many paragraphs, but most notably, in the first and second body paragraphs.

2. I know that I need to revisit the content of my last three paragraphs, as the actual content has yet to be edited since the peer review, other than swapping the order.

3. I would like feedback on the ratios among my AXES structure and where you think I lack the most in content. Additionally, I would like general feedback on the depth of the paper and where you think I could dive deeper into certain claims or topics.

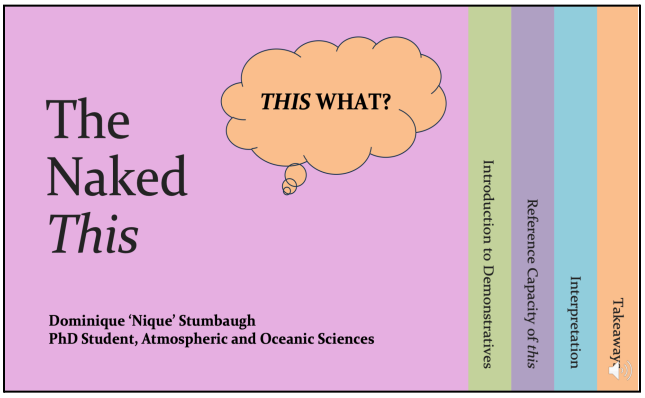
4. I am least confident on the intro and conclusion, as they were thrown in towards the end of writing, without much structure, just based on how I felt I could best introduce and conclude the content of the body paragraphs naturally.

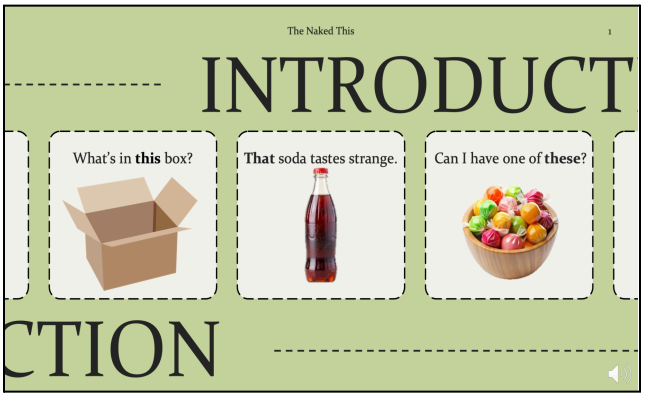
5. I am most confident in my assertions and explanations/analysis, as those were quite strong according to my peer reviewers. My process for making the assertions was at the very beginning, by stringing together assertions in my outline to make the most fluid argument that builds upon each assertion. The analysis was simply expanding on the content/arguments found in my sources, and making inferences into what it means for such a broad and complex/mysterious topic of AI and regulation.

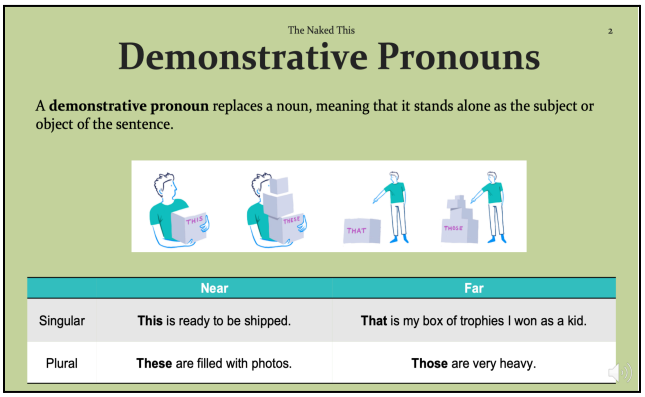
For the cluster courses I've taught, I hold 20 minute conferences with each student at least once a quarter and ask them to come with a current draft of their final project. As preparation for the conference, students must also complete a reflective memo reflecting on their revision up to that point and what revisions they plan to make. I ask them to share what sections they feel the least and most confident about and why. I have found that by having students do these reflections prior to meeting with them, they understand their writing better and have more confidence talking about their writing. I am better able to connect with the students, too, by first addressing issues they have identified. Students become more confident and self-directed as a result of this assignment. Students come to understand that iterating on their writing, regardless of what stage they are at, is a powerful tool. I am also able to build trust with them, as I get a clear insight into their writing process and guild them through their drafts.

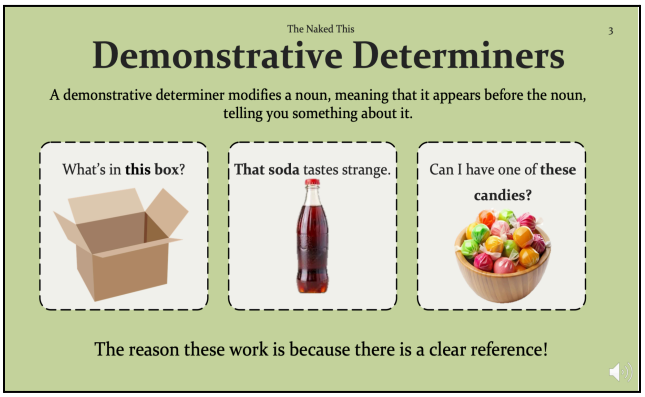
Artifact #5 Grammar Teaching Tutorial (5min Video)

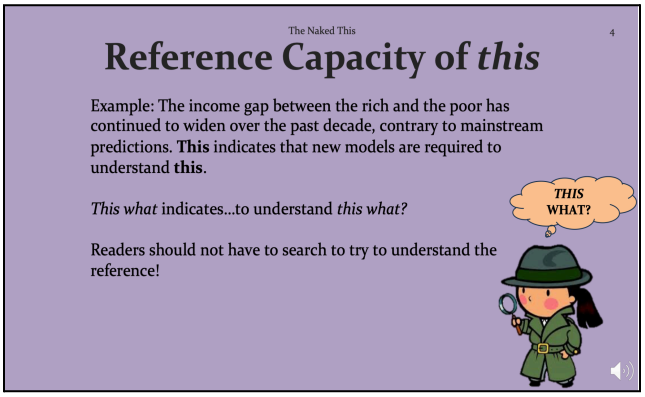
Slides Without Audio:

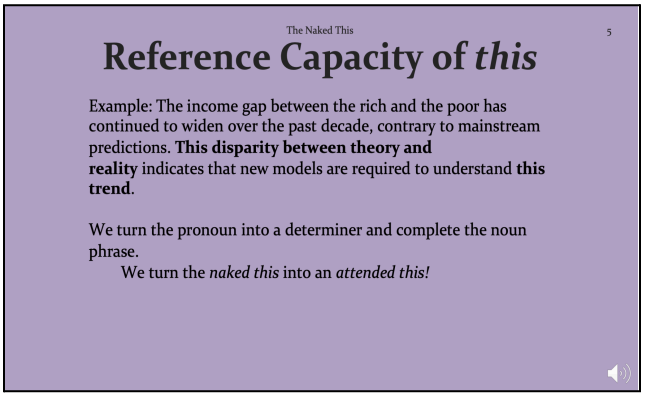


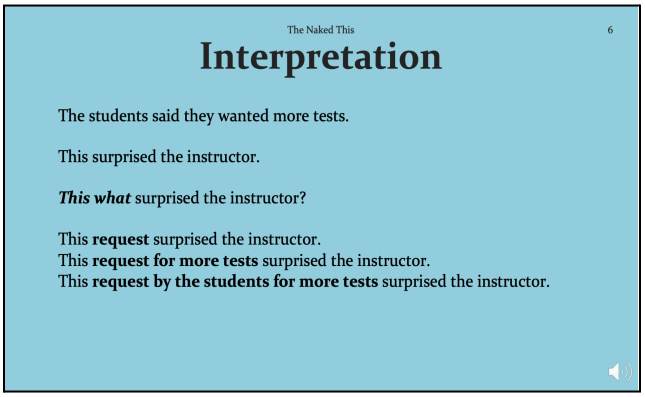


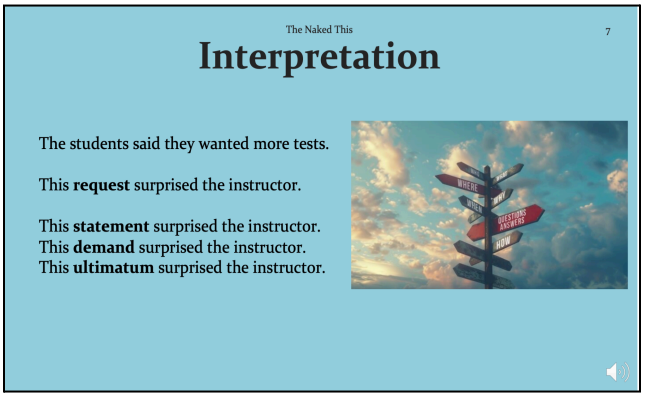


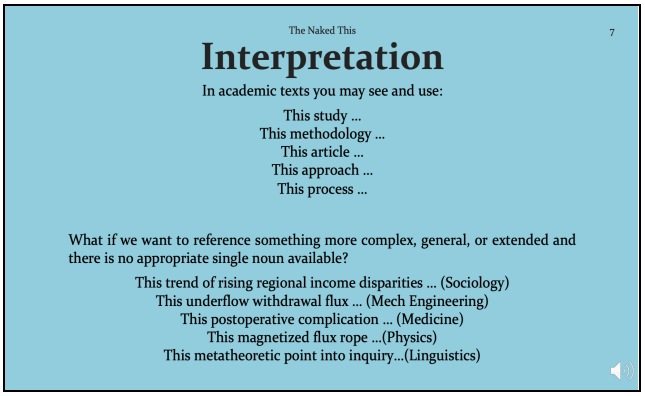


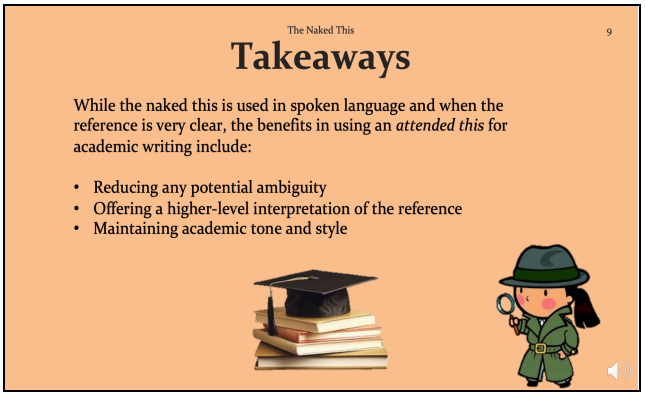














Link to the 5min Tutorial: GTT_DominiqueStumbaugh .mov

I created this student facing, Grammar Teaching Tutorial as part of the Language Pedagogy: Form, Meaning, and Function (EngComp 403) class that I took for the Graduate Certificate in Writing Pedagogy (GCWP). I chose the topic, the naked *this*, in response to reading my students' writing that overused statements that started with "This is.." and introduced confusion and ambiguity in their writing and their thinking about the material they were writing about. Through the grammar class and then this tutorial, I learned ways to teach grammar that is approachable and fun for both native and non-native English writers. After posting this tutorial, I noticed immediate improvements in student's writing when it came to unattended pronouns.

Student Example Sentence: **This** guides countries to sync their AI plans and rules, aiming for global AI standards and practices (Abramov, 2024).

Student Revised Sentence: **The frameworks being worked on** guide countries to sync their AI plans and rules, aiming for global AI standards and practices (Abramov, 2024).

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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UC RIVERSIDE
University Writing Program

1003 HMNSS Building
Riverside, CA 92521

February 5th, 2026
Re: Dominique Stumbaugh
Attn: DTA Selection Committee

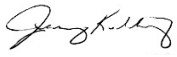
It is with pleasure that I write this letter in support of Dominique Stumbaugh's nomination for the 25-26 Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. As my student, Dominique consistently demonstrated exceptional teaching intuition and an innate ability to put those intuitions into practice. This recommendation highlights what I believe makes her an ideal candidate for this award.

As my student in *English Composition 403: Language Pedagogy: Form, Meaning, and Function*, a core seminar in UCLA's Graduate Certificate in Writing Pedagogy program, Dominique stood out immediately. Not only did she demonstrate profound curiosity toward a subject far removed from her scientific discipline, but also a willingness to fully commit in service of honing her skills as a student-centered writing instructor. Dominique worked diligently to acquire and apply best pedagogical practices, and she did this with a passion I see infrequently; pedagogical grammar isn't the most exciting topic, after all, but it is the foundation to effective writing. Importantly, she didn't just take from this course; she also gave. Her knowledge of the sciences offered productive information that enriched classroom discussions, adding a much-needed, unique perspective on academic science writing practices that are typically underexplored in the Humanities. With each topic covered, Dominique engaged fully, seeing value that could enhance her pedagogical toolkit. She also broadened the scope of understanding for the entire class, and for me as well, through her knowledge of scientific discourse and its associated writing expectations and linguistic conventions. Her viewpoint helped create an environment in which scientific genres of writing were made visibly accessible to us all.

Dominque made clear from the onset that she was well aware of what her students produced in their work, and she was equally clear on her core goal of learning to help them find new pathways and forms of agency in their writing. Her scientific writing knowledge shed welcome light on burgeoning practices in the sciences that many would see as nascent, such as using the *I* pronoun where it was once considered a taboo. For her first assignment, she focused on finding ways of addressing vague pronoun use, in particular what is typically known as *the naked this*. She conceptualized and crafted a five-to-six-minute grammar teaching tutorial video (see Artifact 5) that demonstrated to students how *This* alone loses impact without a subsequent noun, such as in *This statement*. For her second assignment, she developed several original digital lesson plans involving science writing infused with language instruction, providing a visual walkthrough which effectively supplanted traditional text-heavy written lessons plans. With each lesson, she continued to focus on scientific discourse, developing pedagogically sound practices for actively teaching its structures while also showing her students how and when to break its expected shape with purpose.

In sum, I wholeheartedly recommend Dominique for this award. I cannot think of a more deserving candidate, and I sincerely hope that she is strongly considered for this opportunity.

Sincerely,



Jeremy Kelley, PhD
Associate Professor of Teaching
University Writing Program
University of California, Riverside